

THE BIG TICKET ITEMS



NUCLEAR MUSCLE: India will lease an Akula-II nuclear powered submarine from Russia next year.



AIR HORSE: Both countries will acquire over 100 of the jointly developed Multirole Transport Aircraft.



FUTURE FIGHTER: The fifth generation Sukhoi T-50 will be the frontline fighter for both air forces.

given stores when they are near US platforms and bases.

Russia is the only country with which India has a comprehensive defence agreement. The "special relationship" almost wholly revolves around the transfer of military hardware, most of it under a 10-year programme on military-civil technical cooperation signed in 2000 and comprising 13 research and development and production projects estimated to be worth \$18 billion. These include the successful Indo-Russian Brahmos supersonic cruise missile now inducted by the Indian Navy and a hypersonic missile, which is under-development and would be fielded in the next decade. The fifth generation fighter borrows heavily from the success of the Brahmos project. By the 1990s, Russia—the world's only operator of supersonic surface-to-surface missiles—had already perfected the missile but lacked the funds to pursue its development. India stepped in with funds in 1998 and the missile was re-launched as the Brahmos.

The fifth generation fighter aircraft has two critical technologies—stealth, or a drastic reduction in the aircraft's radar cross-section or 'signature' and the ability to 'super cruise' or jet engines that fly stealthily without engaging noisy afterburners even at super-sonic speeds.

Yet, the designs for the aircraft dubbed the PAK-FA T-50 have already been frozen by the Sukhoi design bureau, which means that Indian aircraft engineers have missed out on the

critical knowledge curve of aircraft design. Also, analysts say the unequal status of Indian and Russian aviation industries means India will be the junior partner contributing very little except funds. "We have to analyse the cost-benefits of acquiring only two technologies for \$10 billion," says Kak. Russia has been a willing provider of sensitive technology that no other country would provide. "It has a proven commitment towards India and has supplied us everything from cryogenic engines to nuclear reactors in the face of international opprobrium," says V.G. Jayaprakasan, managing director of Rosoboronservice (India).

Late next year, India will induct INS Chakra, the first Akula-II class nuclear-powered attack submarine now being completed at the Komsomolsk-on-Amur in Russia. Negotiations are on for leasing a second such submarine. The 12,000-tonne submarine with unlimited endurance will give India the ability to flex its maritime muscle in the

Indian Ocean and train crew to operate its indigenous nuclear submarine—the Advanced Technology Vessel. The \$650 million deal with no strings attached carries forward the Cold War legacy of allowing advanced weapon transfers to prevent India from switching over to the Western camp. Only, now ideology has been replaced by market interests.

Russia is determined to protect its dominance of the Indian market from Western interlopers like Israel and the US. India will spend an estimated \$50 billion over the next 10 years to buy arms, most of them force multipliers like the fifth generation fighter to retain qualitative edge over China and Pakistan. Both sides have moved swiftly to resolve major irritants in the transfer of defence equipment—a three-year delay in the delivery of aircraft carrier Vikramaditya—and escalation of costs. Russia has stopped sulking over not being nominated for a \$10 billion global tender to supply 126 MMCA where its MiG-35 is in contest with the US F-16 and F/A-18. It has speeded up spares and after-sales support for the world's largest operator of its equipment. India, in turn, has agreed to a 5 per cent hike in defence contracts worth \$10 billion signed over the past few years. But the irritants remain as do the concerns over the long-term viability of a special relationship centred on arms, especially for competing systems. "The only foreseeable hurdle is the inability of Russian equipment to match the Western systems on technology," says Dr Thomas Mathew, deputy director, Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses.

Clearly the relationship has evolved from a Cold War alliance to one of mutual give-and-take. ■



Russia does not attach strings to the transfer of sensitive technology.



BEAST: India will buy over 1000 T-90 tanks